

While nuns are often seen as apolitical women whose lives are dedicated to worship, many moments in history have seen nuns take a political stand, for example in the Tibetan uprising of 1959. Tibet had been an independent nation ruled by a spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama, but in 1950 it fell under control of the Chinese government, who wanted the Dalai Lama removed. In 1959, as Chinese forces gathered in Lhasa where the Dalai Lama lived, tensions came to a peak. On March 12 that year a group of Tibetan women, including many Buddhist nuns, gathered outside Potala Palace, Lhasa—the Dalai Lama’s residence—and began a non-violent protest against the Chinese occupation. At least 5,000 women joined in the uprising. Chinese forces

responded violently, seeking out the organizers, and placing them under arrest. Among those arrested was a nun named Ghalingshar Choe-la, who was held and tortured for six years, and later died from her injuries. The women’s martyrdom has led to more activism—every year on March 12, activists around the world protest to commemorate the “Women’s Uprising.”

Nuns in Latin America

Catholic nuns following the tenets of liberation theology—which advocates active participation in changing

socioeconomic structures to help the poor—were involved in grassroots organizing for human rights in the 1960s and ’70s. In Brazil, many priests guided by this theology were seen as “leftists”, and arrested and tortured by the military junta after the coup of 1964. Sister Maurina Borges da Silveira was the only Religious Sister to experience the same fate; she was arrested and tortured in 1969, then banished in 1970. During the Salvadoran Civil War (1980–1992), three US nuns, Maura Clarke, Ita Ford, and Ursuline Dorothy Kazel, and a lay missionary, Jean Donovan, worked with the poor and refugees from the war. The military in El Salvador regarded such activities as subversive and, in 1980, the women were beaten, raped, and murdered by Salvadoran death squads. The commitment of nuns to social justice has often put them at risk of imprisonment, torture, and even death.

▲ Church versus state

Greek Orthodox nuns protest against a proposed law to give the Greek government control over the Church’s land. Aside from the state, the Church is Greece’s biggest landowner.



“THE MIRACLE IS NOT THAT WE DO THIS WORK, BUT THAT WE ARE HAPPY TO DO IT.”

MOTHER TERESA, ROMAN CATHOLIC NUN AND MISSIONARY

